Saewulf

The Round

The Loquenaud could easily be mistaken for a museum. From its conception, the Loquenaud was built as a house of order - where representatives can call assembly and speak on public matters that need a wider range of advice or aid. The Round; the hall where the speaking and deliberating actually takes place, has over the years been buried deep in the center of a grand maze of hallways, workplaces, and smaller lecture rooms for meetings on matters and people of lesser importance. The artisans employed for the original expansion of the Loquenaud certainly had their fun adorning the halls and ceilings with symbols of grandeur; long, swathing floral decor, illustrations of foreign landscapes, and so very many accents of gold.

Deeper in the heart of the labyrinthian bureau is a mosaic famously known as "The Champions Tapestry". A hundred-foot stretch of hallway that on the right wall displays a voracious horde of sharp-toothed beasties, short-snouted and red-eyed. Carnivorous and rageful, the horrible lot of them. The left wall depicts a choir of legends; strong-jawed symmetrical faces, muscle-rippled bodies squeezed tightly into glimmering impractical armor that leaves nothing to the imagination, all valiantly wielding weapons unsullied by viscera. According to the two-dozen plaques that underline the mosaic, each hero portrayed was a real individual that fought for Al'Gohjen. Fought for what? I don't know. Fought against who? I imagine the beasties. Famous legends, every one. Famous enough to have their glory immortalized in a million tiny stones. I can't name a damned one of them.

Staring up at the eldritch creatures on the opposite wall however, I feel a terribly unusual blend of discomfort and kinship. I don't want to meet one; I hardly want to look at the tapestry of them as it is. But I feel like I understand them in a way; like their hungry jaws aren't flapping in barks or snarls, but like they're shouting for something. Not sure what a black dog like that would need to shout for, but they seem passionate about it. I sympathize with that. It's a tragedy they're all monsters.

"*Cugail*," A voice rasped from the far end of the hall, "that is what they're called. Or *Cugails* as the plural perhaps." I only glance to get a look at the

approaching voice. He's an old man with snow white hair and puffy bouts of spotted skin hanging on his cheeks and under his eyes. He wears iron gray robes tied at the waist with a leather belt and thick pouch on the left hip. Atop the robe is a pulled-back hood that cloaks the shoulders. Keeping the shoulder capes together are golden medallions on either side connected by a chain - one decorated with a portrait of soft-faced young man with a fine head of curled hair, the other with a human skull. Order and Justice. I wear the same clothing.

"Fascinating creatures, are they?" I ask the old man as he steadies at my side, looking up at the scene with me. He only reaches the height of my shoulder.

"I'd think so, but I haven't been able to find much of a history on them. Certainly are nasty things though, don't you think?"

"I haven't decided yet."

"They *look* rather nasty."

"So does Speaker Aldwin, but he remains rather popular among the Auris." I smile, finally breaking away from the mosaic and turning to properly address the man. He gives me a mischievous smile as he takes me in; I haven't crossed any lines with this man taking a jab at a fellow Speaker. It can be a touchy subject for some of them who take their job too seriously.

"Speaker Kieran." The man introduces himself with an outstretched hand.

I respond in kind, taking his hand, "Saewulf. Still don't quite feel like a Speaker."

"*Speaker Saewulf!*" Kieran's eyes lit up with recognition, "I knew I recognized that salty beard of yours. The speaker for the Vox Vulgis, if I'm not mistaken?"

A tight smile forms on my face, "Indeed."

Kieran lets out a laugh that sounds more like a cough, in a tone I've heard far too often this past year: condescension. The low pitiful laugh of the aged and experienced that asks me "*What have you gotten yourself into*?". I've given up telling them that *I* didn't get myself into this.

"For someone who doesn't feel like a Speaker yet, you do an awful lot of it." Kieran jabs.

"There's a lot to talk about. The Vox Vulgis have a universe of problems: infinite and expanding. All I can do is ask for help." I defend.

Kieran nods, "I've enjoyed your stands, Speaker Saewulf. You have good priorities, you offer solutions, and you appeal to everyone. I do remember a dialogue we shared, I believe it was about the peoples livestock..?"

"I think I remember," I do not, "you offered your opinions."

Kieran laughs thick with phlegm again, "I tend to offer those in excess I'm afraid. But I hope it proved to be useful."

"I'm sure it was, Speaker. And why else should we have these stands if not to talk in excess? That's how we find solutions, isn't it?"

"A fair point," Kieran pats me approvingly on my back, "a very fair point."

A moment of quiet passes over us as a small fleet of identically clothed Speakers pass behind us and enter into the Round at the end of the hallway.

"Perhaps it's time we go in. Lots of problems to solve." I say to Kieran, but he's somewhere else. Still at my side but his eyes look like that of a lost boy, almost afraid, and his mouth hangs only slightly open.

"Go in where?" Kieran whispers, as though sharing a secret.

I pause, and a small pang of familiarity hits me. I remember that lost look in my fathers' eyes when he was in his golden years. They call it "Nebula"; brain fog that comes and goes when you least expect it, until it decides to stop leaving and you're stuck trying to find yourself in a thick mist until you die. He was speaking clearly and coherently, I wonder how long Kieran has had it. My father first showed signs when he was sixty-five. Kieran looks no younger than eighty. It was only a matter of time I suppose, with genetic cases. Poor bastard.

I offer a gentle hand to redirect Kieran towards the Round, "To the Round, Speaker Kieran. We have work to do. Should be about six hours today." I begin walking forward, away from the Cugails, keeping Kieran in front of me.

"Oh," Kieran begins with a few careful moves before stepping into a march, "of course! Busy busy day. Forgive me, got very little sleep these past few nights."

"Nothing to apologize for, it's our nature to lose sleep over problems." I smile and walk behind the old man.

"Quite right!" Kieran lets out a fraternal cackle before rushing into the Round, leaving me to find my place in the cacophony of chattering mouths.

The stand is empty. The Round is thick with the smell of incense and parchment, it makes me want to sleep. I'm seated between Speaker Amos and Speaker Nith, both of which are engaged in conversation with multiple persons seated near them. There's a woman ahead of me in the lower ring of the Round I could speak to, but I'm content staring at the back of her head. Wouldn't want her to strain her neck on small talk. Amos sounds like he's discussing personal dramas about Speaker Nicholas, who isn't here as far as I can see. I'm not opposed to drama, but I respect Nicholas too much to partake. Nith is talking about education. The acceptance rates of the academies in Al'Gohjen have been decreasing in the past couple of years, at a concerning rate; graduation classes have gone from several hundred to ninety-plus some. The biggest class that graduated this past spring was one-hundred-and-six, from the Faulkery Institute. The increased number is not as good as it sounds; the likelihood is that the Auris will see the bigger number from the year prior, say "there's no issue here", and dismiss it. Then the next year, and the year after, the number will continue ever downward.

The Auris Mastra is just another one of hundreds of fancy words the Speakers of the Round have conjured up to reinforce their self-importance. It means "The Mass Ear", and encompasses all of us Speakers under one title. Everybody gets a say, everybody gets a vote, but it always comes down to the majority choice of the Auris. A brilliant thing on paper, but has proven to be remarkably frustrating when you come to find that most of the Speakers of the Round are all narcissists. I'd like to think I'm not guilty of this but I am. Something about the robes, the fancy titles, the power...even sober folks are bound to get drunk if they have enough wine, and my cup has remained generously full.

A lone drop in the pool of gray fabrics strays to the middle of the Round. A brunette woman streaked with silver takes the stand and arranges a stack of papers on one of the six podiums lining the bars. The stack looks thick enough to take up at least two of the six hours we have to spare today. Five and a half now. The woman folds her hands in front of her and holds her chin up, surveying each and every one of us with eyebrows raised in an expectant look; *silence*, her posture demands. Within a minute, her command is heeded, and the Round is quiet. A smile takes on her face as she glances her pages and pulls something from the pouch on her belt: a small clay disc no larger than her palm with intricate geometric carvings etched into the face of it. A rune. She holds the

disc in an open hand with her thumb pressed to the center, and with a bit of pressure it cracks in half and its magic takes hold.

As she speaks, her voice is projected at five times the normal volume; heard as clearly from the back of the room, sixty feet away from the stand, as if she were standing directly in front of them.

"Speaker Verika Briar: standing." She announces. Her voice is bold and so clearly annunciated you'd think she had never stuttered before in her life. "Good morning, all. I want to begin with some distressing news, so that we might know the danger and not let it distract us during our discussions. The Sentry have informed me that a disgruntled radical has planted an incendiary rune somewhere near the Loquenaud. I'd like to repeat: *near*, not *in*. We will remain safe indoors; the Sentry are inspecting the streets as we speak. By the time we have concluded our business, so will the Sentry's have concluded theirs and we will all be well. Are there any questions or further concerns?"

Myself and other Speakers look either direction to each other and find that nobody has anything more to add. Verika nods and proceeds.

"Our first order of business: import. I have multiple letters from business owners stating that their work has been hindered by, quote: 'disappointing goods'. Several hospitality venues, the very taverns and eateries we frequent ourselves, have reported their produce and protein were unpreserved. Their food has approximately half the shelf life it normally does. Not only this, but as you know our provision-dealers count their import and keep a precise stock. For the last few months there has been a steady decrease of the amount of goods coming in."

She turns the page over and lets loose a deep sigh, "Fewer and poorer. And it's not just from Burmosa, it's from Lycrest, it's from Cannabar, and it's from Al'Vicrtia. Nearly all of our main trade partners think they can get away with taking our money and shitting in our hands - letting our people go hungry."

I like this woman. She's not afraid to get angry. Anger is refreshing in a job that demands careful thought and analyses of every angle.

She finishes her opening point by throwing the conversation to the Auris: "I ask you then: What do we believe the cause of this to be, and furthermore, what be the solution?"

The cracking of several runes sound off across the Round, ready to be heard.

"Speaker Midas: sitting." A voice from the opposite side of the room calls out, "I have heard the same complaints, Speaker Verika, and I think the cause to be an obvious one. Our allies have lost respect for us. They see how we have broached discourse and doled out justice and find it weak." Midas' words are met with resounding murmurs of agreement. "*What will they do*? They say, *Fight back*? They believe we will not - which brings me to my proposed solution: prove them wrong. Cut our end of trade entirely."

"A very wise schoolboy approach, Speaker Midas," Verika droles back, "*my people aren't eating enough, so nobody eats at all*. And where will that leave us with several full trade veins cut? What message will that send to the allies that have not yet begun cutting our resources?"

"Speaker Shira: sitting." Another voice chimes in, closer to me. "I don't think we should jump to violence for our solutions, as we have discussed *many times* before." Shira spits. She and Midas have a past of strong disagreement. There's civility in forced seated discussion, but what I wouldn't give to see the two of them have at each other with a pair of swords.

Shira adds, "You say our allies have lost respect for us because of our 'weak problem solving'. Elaborate."

Midas responds, prepared, "We're halfway through our rotation and look at what has occurred; you all remember the debacle with the band of thieves only a month ago - *all* of them escaped with hidden runes. Unchecked! 'The Midsummer Noose-Slip' the name on the street is - an embarrassment! And what about the Children of Red Dog?"

At the name, an uproar of groans sounds out. I'm able to identify the tones of some. Frustration, apathy, indifference and impatience mostly. But behind me I hear a man say "Yes, always *their* fault. Never blame the people in power.". I turn to identify them: Speaker Huss. He never has much to add, nothing useful anyway. He sees me staring. A challenge. I stare longer, making sure not to let so much as a muscle in my face twitch. Huss turns his attention back to the stand, and I win.

Interesting. The Children of Red Dog have supporters in the Auris.

"The Children of Red Dog is a matter we will be returning to at a later time, Speaker Midas, rest assured. Presently, I want to focus solely on finding a solution on the trade matters." Verika attempts to settle the mums of discourse.

Another man speaks over her, "Speaker Detlas: sitting. I propose an assembly with the Meisters of Trade at their earliest convenience. We hear directly from their mouths what their reasoning is and we find a way to correct it that leaves all sides happy."

"The Meisters have already been contacted, multiple times, their earliest convenience is months out which we cannot allow to pass without change." Verika holds her hand up in the direction of Detlas as though to tell him "wait your turn.". He makes a fine argument though - an ideal one, I should say. Midas speaks the dilemma aloud before I can finish forming the thought:

"Speaker Detlas, there has never been a solving of problems where every party leaves *truly* happy. We can only hope for most. And to the point of Speaker Verika, we do not have the time to spare. Which is why we should act quickly. If we halt our trade that leaves more food for our people to have. We act independently for a short while and then the bitches who tried to get one over on us will be begging for a meeting at *our* soonest convenience."

Perhaps Midas should fight all of the Speakers. He certainly has the mouth to bring it on.

"Trade serves more purpose than just sustenance - Speaker Midas. Partnership, good faith,"

"-Which they are not showing to us!" Midas interrupts.

"*Finance!*" Verika bites. "Cutting off our allies leaves us operating as an independent nation. An island. We only grow food to feed ourselves. What happens when our crops are out of season, or if our animals get sick? What if some uppity noble decides to start a civil war, or the crime families shake hands and decide to kill and rob whomever they please?"

"Like the Children of Red Dog!" Shira squeals, drawing the ire of Verika.

"As I said - The Children of Red Dog is a matter we *will* tend to later! If we cut off trade or give our allies reason to cut us off entirely, we will be alone in our matters, which - according to you, Speaker Midas, we are handling poorly enough as it is. Would you rather we have no lifeboat to call for, should the streets run red? Would you rather see Al'Gohjen eat itself alive?"

Midas' fighting words fail him. Verika flips another page and wipes a bit of sweat from her brow.

Midas is a cunt, I'm confident in that, but he's a charming cunt. He has a certain pride about him I find admirable. He sits more than he stands within the Round, but he always seems eager to jump to the last resort for everyone's cause. It's brash and unnecessary, but he's willing to fight dirty for the people and the nation he cares about. Sometimes I wish more people were like that. Other times, not so much. I try to play between Midas and Detlas.

I pull a clay rune from my pouch and snap it in half under my thumb. I feel my throat swell and a large puff of air inflate my lungs. It's uncomfortable but it's necessary to be effective. I tuck the broken halves in a second, less fancy pouch that looks more akin to a scrotum. I have nine remaining.

I throw myself into the frying pan, "Speaker Saewulf Riven: sitting. May I ask, Speaker Verika, how your addresses to the meisters was worded?"

Verika turns in my direction and her coffee eyes search for me. They fall about three people to my left as she responds:

"In approximation or exact?"

"Exact if you can."

She turns four papers up and pulls the fifth out of the pile and begins reading:

"*To Meister Brianne Erid of Lycrest,*

The Round writes to you with complaints and concerns about your latest shipments. Many of our tradespeople have found your supply lacking in quantity and quality. Our arrangement states that we will have equal trade of previously agreed upon conditions - the hardworking people of Al'Gohjen have consistently delivered on their end of this mutually beneficial trade, and they expect respectful reciprocation. If Lycrest has come into hardship that hinders you and your people from supplying the full amount of your end, a new placeholder arrangement can be made.

I would like to formally request an in person assembly at the Loquenaud in Al'Gohjen to discuss the matter in greater depth so that we might better understand each other and come to an agreement. Similar invitations will be extended to the Meisters of Burmosa, Cannabar, and Al'Vicrtia.

Respond at your earliest convenience, I look forward to your company.

- Sincerely, Speaker Verika Briar of The Round"

"That's all?" I say, perhaps with more snideness than intended.

"Yes," Verika folds the letter and raises a brow at who she thinks is me, "that *is* all. You think it insufficient, Speaker Saewulf?"

"I think it just fine for a first sending. But they responded with unsatisfactory terms to a problem they are responsible for. I like the formality of your wording but perhaps we should send a second letter out to the Meisters with a fraction of Midas' rage."

A single triumphant cackle booms in the Round from Midas.

"Elaborate." Verika demands.

"Don't attack, but challenge. Something just eloquent enough to be shy of a threat." My suggestion is met with a slight head tilt that suggests intrigue from the standing Speaker.

"How would you phrase this letter, give me an example." She begins to pace around the stand as I conjure a mental draft.

"*We have heard your response and find your lack of efficiency or concern unacceptable. We have our people to consider and action must be taken before the next trade voyage.*" There are no murmurs of approval or disapproval to give me any idea if my improvisation is agreeable. I go on, "*An assembly in person would be preferable but if you cannot make the voyage, a meet via long distance divination may be arranged. If either of these proposals are ignored, our arrangement will need immediate reconsideration.*"

I let the words sit and look around me to gauge reactions. My gaze is not met but I receive some subtle nods of support. I look to Verika, who has halted her pacing to consider my words. Her head is aimed down and her eyes are closed. She is waiting for me to finish.

"*We hope we will not need to turn to this final resort. Similar invitations will be extended to the Meisters of Burmosa, Cannabar, and Al'Vicrtia.*

Respond at your earliest convenience.

- Sincerely, Speaker Saewulf Riven of The Round"

More unintelligible dialogue sound off in the Round. I can't tell if I have majority support on this or not, but Verika seems pleased as she raises her head with a clever smile creasing her lips.

"Very direct, Speaker Saewulf. I think a second letter would be wise to send out." Verika offers a single nod up at me, actual me this time, and turns her attention to another side of the Round. "Does anyone dispute this, or have any alternate solutions they think superior?"

"What if the Meisters do deny the invitation; the face-to-face and the divination. How would we propose to alter our arrangement? Independent nation?" Detlas speaks again and starts up a new wave of floundering suggestion, each person trying to have their words heeded over others. Some are here because they genuinely care about the matters and want to see change, others simply want to be right and be recognized for it. I feel the Auris is split just about perfectly in half in that regard, at least since I've joined. I wonder if it was always this way. It's hard to imagine it any other way, as bleak as that may seem.

Round and round the discussion goes. After an hour my lungs settle back down and the tightness in my throat eases away. I feel as though I've loosed a single, massive, long-held breath. The physical relief is divine, but to my ears and my head there is no peace. Nith and Amos have both cracked a rune and have been blasting their considerations towards Verika any chance they get. Another hour passes and Nith and Amos crack another rune, as do Midas and Shira. Detlas doesn't have anything to say worth cracking another rune. He and I, and hundreds of others, observe the verbal sport between two dozen Speakers.

Verika has claimed more time than I thought she would. The fourth hour passes and I realize we have returned to the matter of why our trade has been disturbed; a conversation I thought handled in the second hour, but I may have fallen asleep for a spell. At some point all the overlapping shouts turn into a sound not unlike waves crashing into the shoreline. It's hypnotic and terribly boring if you're not the one speaking.

In an instant, all sleep is shaken away from my head and my blood runs cold as a horrible eruption sounds from behind me and rattles my intestines. Shaky and unblinking, I slowly turn to look behind me, half expecting to see a burning hole where twenty-odd Speakers were sat. Instead I see the backs of their heads, in tact, and all looking to the tall, narrow windows arranged behind us.

The five windows directly behind me show only a thick plume of black smoke billowing upwards from an unseen source below. No one speaks in the Round, but the incessant whispers continue as always. I cannot say for the others, but I am waiting for a second explosion. Possibly a third. It does not come, but the shrapnel does. Splints of wood between the size of my finger and

my leg begin falling from the sky, all spinning and burning in terrible infernal pirouettes. Chunks of pavement: stone and dirt begin to fall as well, and stray bits of metal from signs and reinforcements that were near the initial blast.

Only through careful focus am I able to hear the screams through the whispers of my surrounding Speakers. Shouts of panic from bystanders I can only imagine from my high seat, and closer more guttural cries from the unfortunate people close enough to the attack to be victims.

"They're dead!" A woman calls to someone, "They're all dead! All of them!" She sounds like she is about to throw up. Debris is still falling, and through the cuts of wood I glimpse a single armored arm of a Sentry re-entering orbit with the rest. I think of other limbs I may have mistaken for stone or lumbar in the craze.

I stand and shuffle to the nearest steps, I have to go out and help. I'm not a healer or law enforcer, but I have to do something. I wait for others to join me and as I turn to look for any followers, I find I am alone.

The terror continues outside as the Speakers that sit around my old position turn their attention back to Verika at the stand. I stare at them in disbelief, then to the rest of the Round. I find Kieran in the crowd, his white hair standing out from the others and he wears that same lost look I saw by the mural. How confused and frightened he must be.

The only other Speaker standing is Verika. Her eyes are as terrified as mine, but she swallows any words of pity or fear and instead turns to the final page in her stack.

"I think," Verika's voice overpowers the screams just beyond the walls. Her voice breaks only slightly, but still doesn't stutter as she says, "it's time we discuss the matter of the Children of Red Dog..."